from Persia and Afghanistan in 1921. In typical Great Game thinking, Russia was the one power which could cause humiliation for the British Empire, and hence was the true enemy; pan-Islamism and Asian nationalism were simply irritants. The Indian government instead tended to believe that it was the practical problem of having a pan-Islamic-nationalist-Bolshevik syndicate of mass popular discontent in South Asia that was the real threat to Britain's imperial position. Therefore, it was not so concerned with becoming entangled in shows of diplomatic strength with Russia.

The trouble for Curzon, Montagu and others in London, was that despite their desire to see their empire win out against the Bolshevik regime, times had changed since the Great Game. Whether they chose to recognise it or not, Persia and Afghanistan were no longer to be subservient to the empire. If Britain wanted to retain its authority in the region, it needed to change tactics from the pre-war period. The battle for influence in South Asia was now to be one of subtlety and persuasion – 'soft' power, as it were – rather than of imperial bluster and condescension. The power-play that had characterised Anglo-Russian rivalry during the Great Game was no longer applicable. The events of 1920 had demonstrated this. The Indian government had been perpetually trying to persuade the Home government of just this fact. When would London finally pay heed remains to be seen.